

Dream swing for fans

PHILADELPHIA (AP) — When the 24 baseball buffs reminisce about their "dream swing," they won't be talking about the home-run swipes of Reggie Jackson or Mike Schmidt.

Not that they haven't seen the Yankees' slugger or the Phillies' power hitter. In fact, they saw 10 major league ballparks, 17 teams, the Baseball Hall of Fame, the Babe Ruth Shrine, and some even witnessed feisty Oakland A's manager Billy Martin holding court in a bar in Cleveland.

The fans' "dream swing" through the major leagues also included two all-night bus rides. The tour, believed the first of its kind, covered 3,500 miles between Detroit, where it started Aug. 1, and Chicago, where it ended Sunday.

And in between were hours of baseball trivia, first-class hotels, 21 meals and a never-ending supply of beer.

"It was the best vacation bargain I've ever run across," said David Spillane, 55, a manufacturer's representative from suburban Bryn Mawr. "It was more than a baseball trip. It was a people trip — real, genuine people with a common interest."

"Look, I've been in a lot of places, and I've met a lot of people," said Randall Palmer, 55, a Gary, Ind., steelworker. "This is the best bunch I've ever been with. Baseball fans, they're the most beautiful people in the world."

They must have been to be awakened at 3 a.m. on one bus ride to Spillane's call of "trivia time. Who was the manager of the Phillies just before Gene Mauch?"

Somebody knew that Andy Cohen handled the Phillies one game in 1960 before Mauch succeeded Eddie Sawyer.

"Anybody tries to talk football or anything like that, we tell him to get lost," cautioned Charlie Morris, 30, a Elyria, Ohio, construction worker.

The fans were as typically American as the game they pursued. They ranged in age from 12-year-old Kerry Nigemyer of Toledo, Ohio, to 71-year-old Floyd Filson, a retired engineer from Westport, Conn. Two couples, seven women, three residents of Arizona, a recent graduate of Yale Law School and a bookkeeper from Lincoln, Neb., made the trip.

So did Brad Betker, 23, a sports writer from Carbondale, Ill., whose ulcer flared up on the second day. "Ulcer or no ulcer, I wouldn't have missed this," said Betker, who managed with warm milk, crackers and perseverance.

Kerry was joined by her grandmother, Virginia Wilcox, 64, of Waynesburg. "Well, my daughter thinks I'm crazy, but I'm having fun, and so is Kerry," said Mrs. Wilcox.

The trip was the brainchild of Charles Laterza, 26, treasurer of the Clyde, Ohio, board of education. Laterza charged each fan \$849, ending up \$700 in the hole. "I always wanted to make a trip like this, so I can't complain about running a few hundred dollars over budget."

Laterza spent \$150 for an ad last January in the Sporting News, the national baseball weekly. The wire services picked up the story, and similar-minded fans responded.

Besides Detroit and Chicago, the tour members also saw games in Boston, Philadelphia, Baltimore, Pittsburgh, Cincinnati, and New York.

Southern 500 pole spot goes to D. Waltrip

DARLINGTON, S.C. (AP) — Darrell Waltrip used only one of two allotted qualifying laps to edge Cale Yarborough Thursday for the pole position for Monday's Southern 500 at Darlington Raceway.

Waltrip flashed around the 1½ mile asphalt track at a speed of 153.838 mph, while Yarborough's best time was 153.766 mph.

It was the Franklin, Tenn., speedster's fourth first-place start this season to 10 poles for Yarborough, a native of nearby Timmonsville, S.C.

Benny Parsons of Ellerbe, N.C., was third at 153.239 mph, Buddy Baker of Charlotte, N.C., fourth at 152.920, and Neil Bonnett of Hueytown, Ala., fifth at 152.422.

Rounding out the top 12 qualifiers Thursday were David Pearson of Spartanburg, S.C., Donnie Allison of Hueytown, Ala., Dale Earnhardt of Kannapolis, N.C., Harry Gant of Taylorsville, N.C., Terry Labonte of Corpus Christi, Texas, Bill Elliott of Lawsonville, Ga., and Bobby Allison of Hueytown, Ala.

Qualifying for the \$266,100 Winston Cup Grand National stock car race will continue Friday and Saturday.